annual flow of Burmese refugees rose to several hundred, and they were based in two refugee camps set up by the Indian government in Leikun (Manipur) and Champhai (Mizoram). Some of these migrants were ‘Chins’, Christian tribals claiming to have escaped religious persecution in Buddhist-majority Burma. Another community which consistently faced the brunt of religious persecution in Burma were the Muslim Rohingyas, who had moved several generations ago from Chittagong in present-day Bangladesh to settle in new agricultural frontiers in the Arakan. They sought refugee status sporadically in Bangladesh since the 1970s and suffered heavily in 2016–17 under state-sponsored persecution in Myanmar. Over a half a million Rohingyas now live in Bangladesh while another 40,000 are estimated to be in India.

The Partition of 1937 and the traumatic ordeal of 1942 were pivotal events that marked the end of an era of active Indo-Burmese migrant links. The first Burmese refugee crisis pre-dated the 1947 Partition crisis by a few years and gave valuable lessons to political leaders and members of the Indian Civil Services in relief and rehabilitation work. This would prove to be of immense value in tackling the next crisis, more gigantic in scale and viciousness than anything in the past.

The Partition of 1947: India and Pakistan

The word ‘prepone’, as opposed to postpone, is widely used in India but was added to the Oxford English dictionary only in 2010.[13] Its historic use in India could be related with the fact that the country was formed by an act of ‘preponement’ in a land accustomed to postponement. On June 3 1947, Louis Mountbatten (1900–79), the last Viceroy of India, brought forward the departure date of British exit by nearly a year to 15 August 1947, leaving little time for administrative preparation in a region with over 300 million people. By then, Partition seemed inevitable after a seven-year-long political agitation by the Muslim League, skilfully led by Muhammad Ali Jinnah (1876–1948). In the absence of Partition, it was argued that Muslims would suffer under Hindu dominance in undivided India, a point bitterly